

US Communications Infrastructure & Global Digital Assets

Data Centers & Neoclouds: How much is a megawatt worth?



Madison Rezaei
+1 917 344 8622
madison.rezaei@bernsteinsg.com



Gautam Chhugani
+91 226 842 1416
gautam.chhugani@bernsteinsg.com



Nancy Wu
+1 917 344 8545
nancy.wu@bernsteinsg.com



Mahika Sapra
+91 226 842 1408
mahika.sapra@bernsteinsg.com



Sanskar Chindalia
+91 226 842 1445
sanskar.chindalia@bernsteinsg.com



Harsh Misra
+91 226 842 1457
harsh.misra@bernsteinsg.com

Almost every time a splashy GPU cloud or colocation contract hits, we get questions on whether that is a “good deal”. Today, we look at the \$/MW of the public data center and neocloud companies, in addition to benchmarking the publicly announced deals with other private providers. We continue to prefer the colo model to the neocloud model, but can appreciate that some neocloud contracts are quite attractive, particularly when the neocloud owns its own real estate.

Revenue/MW is a frequently assessed metric for both colo and cloud deals (not always rightly so). It can vary dramatically by business model, location of capacity, time to service, contract duration, and size of deal. We’ve seen ranges from **<\$1M to \$55M/MW**. Generally, neocloud models look attractive on a revenue basis with very high \$/MW, but when you layer in opex, actual performance varies.

Colocation model: landlord-style REITs sell powered capacity on long-term leases - either on more of a retail or wholesale basis. They serve a broad base: enterprise, hyperscaler, and sometimes neocloud customers, anchoring pricing and utilization. Increasingly, we see emerging AI infra providers (WULF, CIFR) playing with this model. The highest revenue per MW in this space unsurprisingly belongs to EQIX (\$5M/MW), who has a retail-focused model, layering services and interconnection revenue on top of a valuable major metro footprint. More wholesale-type models end up in the \$3-\$4M range, with the emerging entrants lower on a per-MW basis than the established REITs. This likely has to do with available capacity and location—DLR, EQIX, and CoreSite all have strong footprints in top markets and can sell capacity immediately, whereas the emerging players are in more rural areas and mostly preselling for yet-to-be-completed builds.

GPU cloud model: The main players in this space are CRWV, NBIS, and IREN, though we are seeing other non-neocloud players announce competitive large-scale deals. Since the neoclouds are offering a vertically integrated solution, monetizing the same MWs with hardware and services on top of the real estate, the \$/MW levels are higher. Scarce/near-term capacity, fungible terms, and shorter contract durations or flexible contract-outs (for example, 90-day terms instead of traditional 5-year leases) increase the value per MW.

Return differences: Colocation providers are relatively asset-heavy but OpEx-light; while they incur the upfront cost of developing and building facilities, once a data center is stabilized, ongoing operating costs are comparatively low. A significant portion of power and facility-related OpEx is either passed through to customers or embedded within lease structures. By contrast, neocloud providers are RE-light (generally, some are building themselves) but remain capital-intensive as they bear the cost of GPU purchases and see correspondingly high CapEx levels.

Across our coverage, we continue to prefer the colo model over the cloud model for subscale providers. The emerging AI infra providers represent an interesting counterpoint to traditional REITs as they look to pursue the same model on a higher-risk, potentially higher-reward basis. Without a ton of history, it’s hard to assess them on the same basis today.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	22 Jun 2026		Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	EBITDA (M)				Adjusted P/E (x)		
		Cur	Closing Price			Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
DLR (Digital Realty)	O	USD	195.54	232.00	(13.7)%	USD	3.87	2.74	2.37	50.5	71.5	82.4
EQIX (Equinix)	O	USD	1,115.94	1,222.00	1.2%	USD	14.96	17.88	21.36	74.6	62.4	52.2
AMT (American Tower)	O	USD	176.43	207.00	(44.1)%	USD	5.40	6.60	7.08	32.7	26.7	24.9
CRWV (CoreWeave)	U	USD	111.29	67.00	(64.6)%	USD	(1.20)	(4.20)	(2.41)	38.4	15.1	8.0
IREN (IREN)	O	USD	56.87	100.00	418.0%	USD	269.67	233.06	1,296	81.9	94.7	17.0
CIFR (Cipher)	O	USD	28.14	32.00	617.3%	USD	22.24	50.72	636.93	700.1	306.9	24.4
WULF (TeraWulf)	O	USD	28.31	36.00	631.7%	USD	(23.11)	115.77	768.30	(17.0)	(16.3)	(49.1)
CORZ (Core Scientific)	O	USD	29.08	32.00	120.0%	USD	(29.66)	276.21	630.77	(33.0)	(31.5)	111.8
RIOT (Riot)	O	USD	28.63	30.00	174.3%	USD	164.30	281.69	405.58	(14.7)	21.0	(37.0)
SPX			7,472.79									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

DLR, EQIX, AMT, CRWV estimate is Adjusted EPS; CRWV, IREN, CIFR valuation is EV/EBITDA (x); WULF, CORZ, RIOT valuation is Reported P/E (x);

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

U.S. Communications Infrastructure: We value DLR on a Price to Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our \$232 price target is based on 27x our 2027E AFFO per share of \$8.52.

We value EQIX on a Price to Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our \$1,222 price target is based on 25x our 2027E AFFO per share of \$48.63.

We value AMT on a Price to NTM Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our \$207 price target is based on 18x our 2027E AFFO per share of \$11.49.

We value CRWV on an EV/Adjusted EBIT multiple. Our \$67 price target is based on an Enterprise Value calculated as 28.4x our 2027E Adj. EBIT per share of \$5.81.

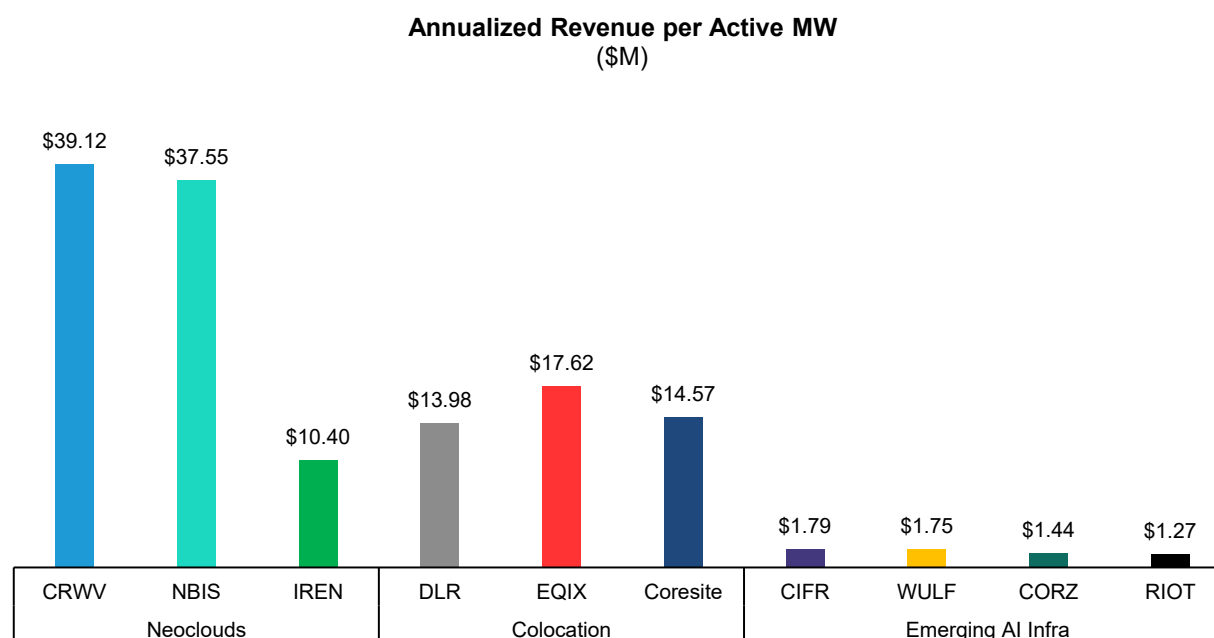
Bitcoin Miners/Emerging AI Infra: Crypto miners remain well positioned to solve 'time to compute' given their planned 30GW power portfolio and operating ability to deliver 'warm powered shells' in time. Over the past two years, miners have contracted 6 GW of power capacity to hyperscalers, neoclouds and AI-chip manufacturers across 17 deals worth over \$110Bn. The contracted 6 GW represents ~20% of the 30 GW pipeline of crypto miners, allowing runway for new contracts. We rate WULF Outperform (PT\$36), CIFR Outperform (PT\$32), IREN Outperform (PT\$100), CORZ Outperform (PT\$32), RIOT Outperform (PT\$30), CLSK Outperform (PT\$24), and MARA Market-Perform (PT\$17)

DETAILS

A number of factors could impact the unit economics of how much value can be extracted from a megawatt of active power, depending on the operating model, customer mix, and service stack of the business. While landlord-style colocation REITs sell primarily powered capacity via long-term leases, neoclouds like CoreWeave are vertically integrated GPU cloud providers that monetize the same one MW with more IT and software services on top. Specifically, Digital Realty, Equinix, and CoreSite focus on 2-15 year leases for blocks of capacity, trading away usage volatility for stable, lower-margin lease revenue per MW. On the other hand, CoreWeave buys or leases the same physical capacity (from other colo providers), fills it with GPUs and resells compute with platform tooling, enabling higher revenue density per MW. They are capturing value from both the infrastructure and application layer. Lastly, emerging AI infra players (former crypto miners) span both ends of the spectrum, with IREN operating a vertically integrated neocloud model while other players (CIFR, WULF, CORZ etc.) follow a colocation-based, power-landlord style model which drives divergence in revenue intensity per MW despite access to similar underlying power assets.

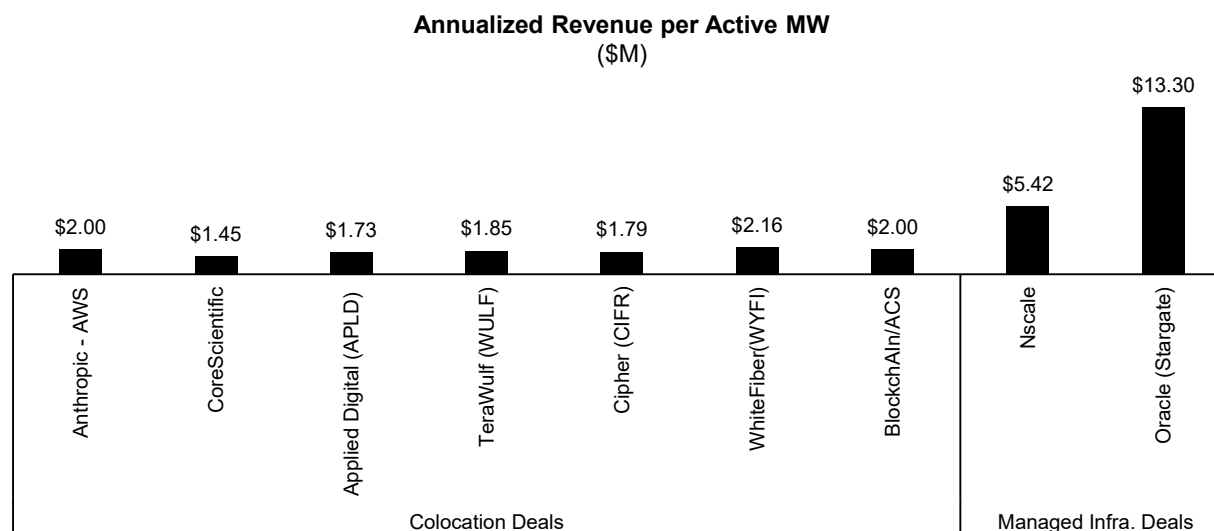
In this note, we examine per-MW revenue, OpEx, and CapEx across our coverage and the two different business models—colocation providers and neoclouds—to highlight how customer mix, stack position, scale, and capital intensity drive wide dispersion in unit economics.

EXHIBIT 1: **Resume Annualized Revenue per Active MW (\$M) per Segments**



Emerging AI & IREN figures are calculated based on a per contract basis.
Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 2: Annualized Revenue per Active MW (\$M) by Other AI Contracts

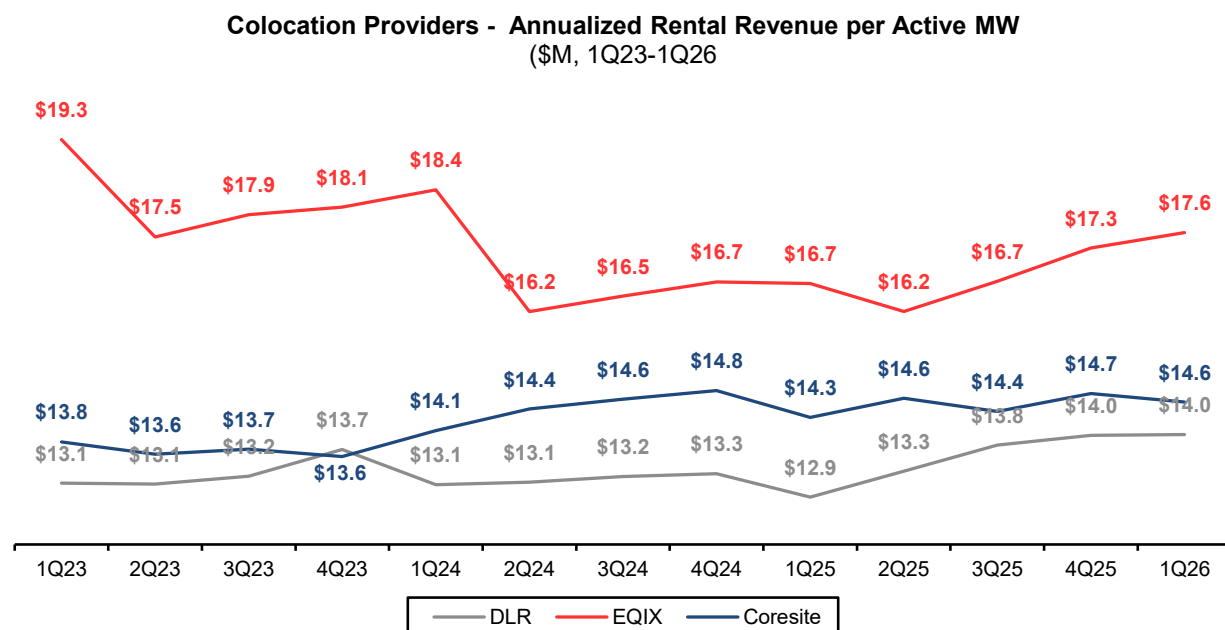


Source: Company filings and public disclosures, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

CUSTOMER MIX AND PRICING POWER

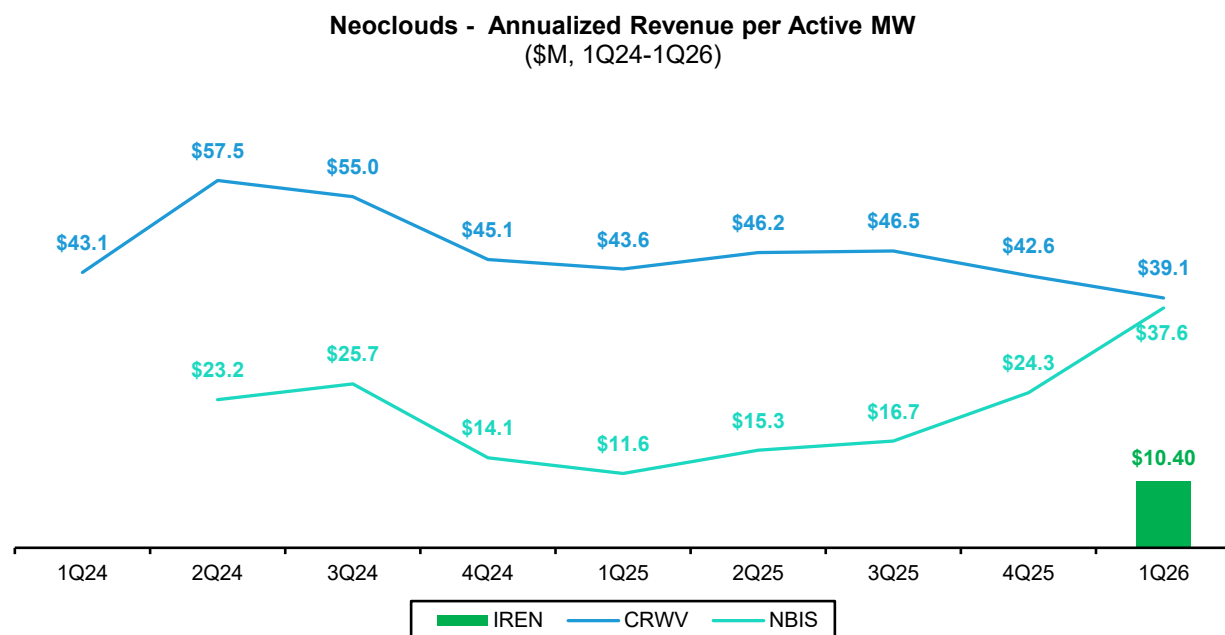
- Colocation model:** Digital Realty, Equinix, and CoreSite serve a broad mix of enterprise, network, and hyperscaler customers, while CoreWeave is concentrated in AI-heavy workloads needing dense GPUs. This customer composition changes average utilization, term, and pricing structures per MW. Equinix and CoreSite have historically skewed towards retail colo and interconnection, with many smaller customers at lower power densities but high cross-connect and networking revenue; this is evident in their revenue per MW figures of \$4.7M and \$3.8M (3-yr average basis), compared with Digital Realty's heavier weight towards wholesale and hyperscaler deals with large tenants, resulting in lower effective pricing per MW of \$3.4M.
- GPU cloud model:** In comparison, neoclouds like CoreWeave and Nebius have higher revenue-per-MW figures of \$20.8M and \$8.4M respectively (on average from FY24-25), due to their customer base of mostly AI labs, startups, and enterprises that need large pools of GPUs for training and inference. They can sustain higher, near 24/7 utilization and maximize monetizable compute hours, allowing them to sign large multi-year deals at premium rates and ultimately driving relatively higher revenue per deployed MW. IREN's customer mix, on the other hand, is anchored by long-term hyperscaler contracts (Microsoft, NVIDIA) along with enterprise clients at their Canada sites, with revenue-per-MW \$10.4 Mn/IT-MW basis contracted capacity, positioning it close to neocloud peers CRWV and NBIS. IREN's position is contingent on timely delivery to hyperscale clients and further buildout of their 5.8 GW owned global power portfolio.
- AI infrastructure players** (CIFR, WULF, CORZ etc.) serve both hyperscalers and neoclouds under long duration (10-15 year) colocation agreements that result in stable, but comparatively lower revenue, at \$1.75 Mn/IT-MW reflecting landlord style monetization of power capacity. WULF and CORZ currently have contracts with neoclouds such as CoreWeave, Core 42 and Fluidstack (backed by Google) while CIFR fares better with 2/3 long term contracts with AWS and the remaining with Google backed Fluidstack. In the colocation business, obtaining hyperscaler rent guarantees and/or stake through warrants acts as a major catalyst for contracts and proof of pedigree, with focus shifting to timely design, procurement and execution.

EXHIBIT 3: **Colocation Prov - Annualized Q Rental Revenue per Active MW (\$M, 1Q23-1Q26)**



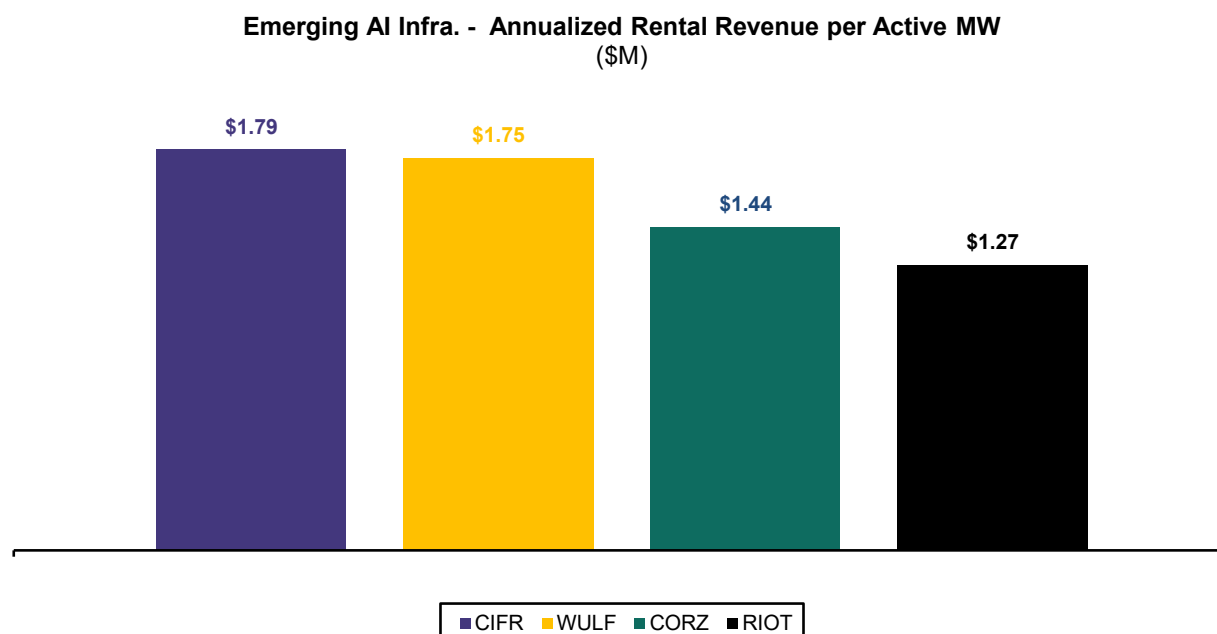
Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 4: **Neoclouds - Annualized Q Revenue per Active MW (\$M, 1Q24-1Q26)**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 5: **Emerging AI Infra. - Annualized Rental Revenue per Active MW (\$M)**



Emerging AI figures are calculated based on a per contract basis.

Source: Company filings and public announcements, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

WHO BEARS THE OPEX?

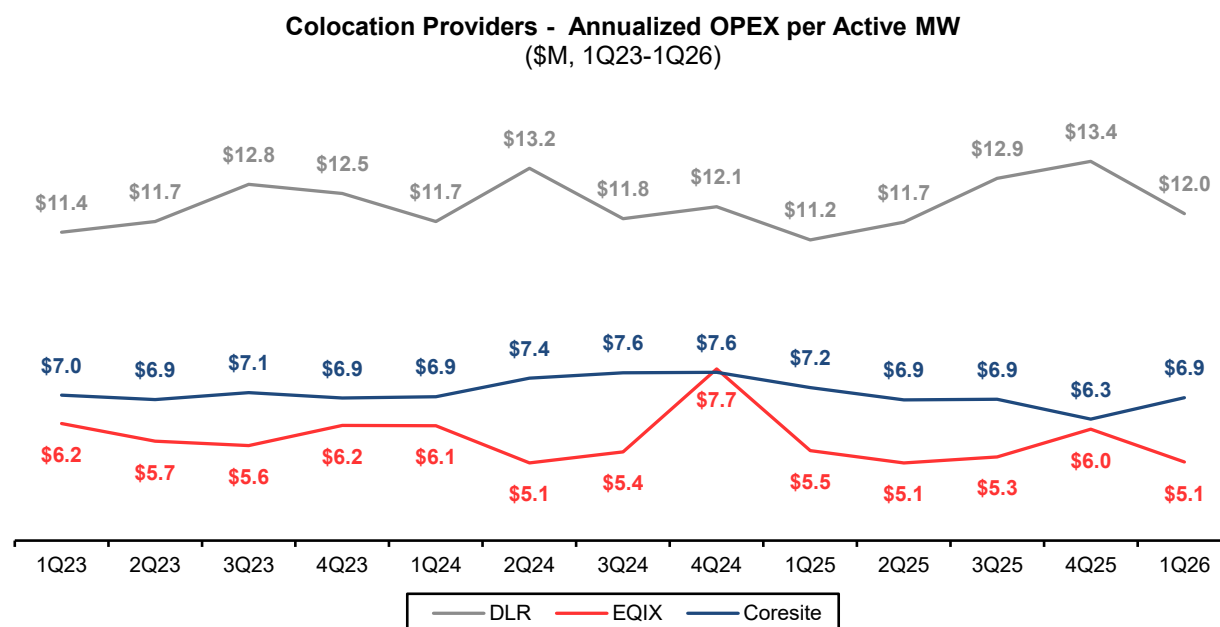
- Colocation model:** For Digital Realty, Equinix, and CoreSite, a significant portion of power and operating costs is either passed through to customers or structured in lease economics, whereas neoclouds incur most of the OpEx directly on their P&L. Interestingly, operating margin per MW nets out to 8.2% for Digital Realty but 66.2% for Equinix, likely due to the higher mix of retail and higher-margin interconnection business, increased pricing power, and a less development-heavy P&L.
- GPU cloud model:** On the other hand, neoclouds buy power, operate the IT stack, and bundle these services into the compute price. They also bear the cost of GPU depreciation, orchestration software, and support engineering, which also sit as a layer on top of the physical infrastructure cost, leading to a comparatively higher OpEx per MW figure. Notably, while the three colocation REITs incur an average of \$2.2M of OpEx per MW, CoreWeave and Nebius post a whopping \$18.6M and \$33.3M respectively, on average annually from FY24-25. CoreWeave's operating margin per MW, at 10.8%, is within range of Digital Realty, while Nebius is still earlier stage and not yet breaking even on a per-MW basis. IREN bears the full OpEx including power procurement, GPU depreciation, and cloud operations, driving higher absolute OpEx per MW but also higher revenue capture.
- Emerging AI infra:** The distinction is evident here as well: Companies like CIFR, WULF, CORZ enter into long-term contracts in the form of gross net deals (typically ~70-90% NOI margins) or triple net (NNN) deals (~100% NOI margin), and pass through either most or all power and operating costs to tenants resulting in structurally lower OpEx per MW and higher EBITDA margins at the asset level. The average margin across bitcoin miners pivoting to AI colocation deals is ~85%, expected to improve as the companies land better contracts (progressing towards triple net) with proven execution.

SCALE, UTILIZATION, AND MARGINS

- Colocation model:** Digital Realty and Equinix both have large global footprints with relatively mature utilization patterns, while neoclouds are still in rapid growth and scaling into high-demand AI workloads. Both dynamics affect revenue intensity and the efficiency of OpEx per MW. Large REITs aim for high occupancy but still carry some underutilized capacity and development pipeline, so some MW of "active" power may not yet be fully revenue-generating, diluting revenue per MW but supporting long-term growth. Their OpEx is spread across a mix of stabilized and ramping facilities—which explains Digital Realty's relatively lower per-MW margin when compared with Equinix.

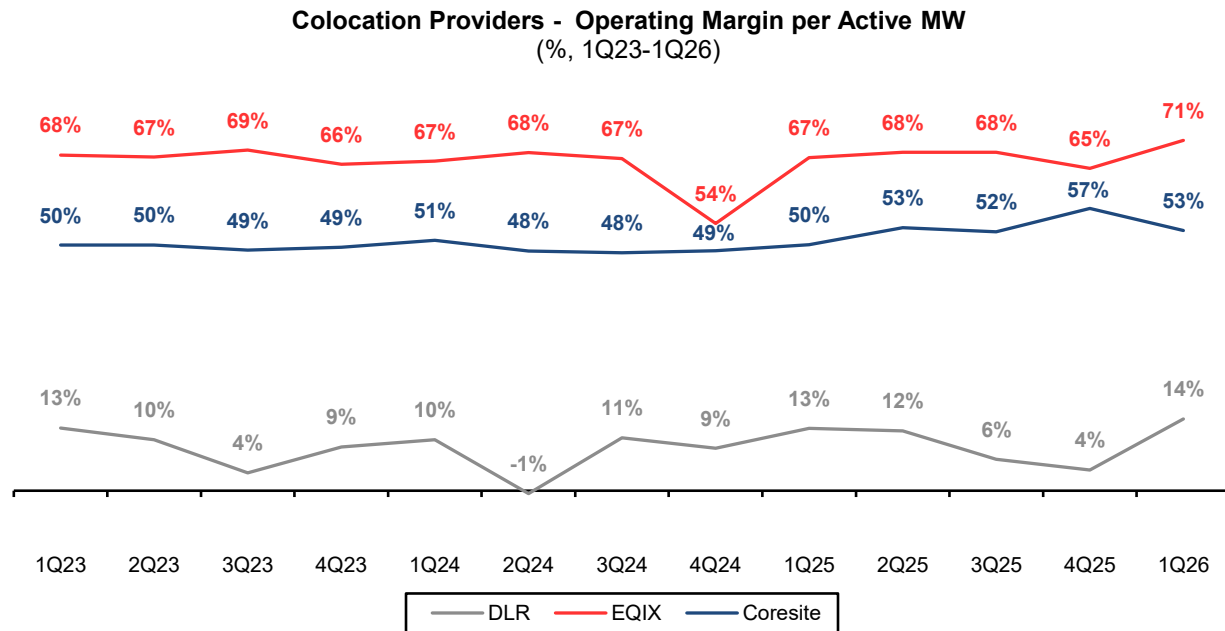
- GPU cloud model:** Neoclouds have achieved strong top-line growth on the back of building concentrated GPU footprints as AI demand surged, but the high revenue per MW also requires intensive spend on infrastructure and networking. In effect, the colocation REITs in our coverage optimize for steady, lower-risk returns on capital per MW, while neoclouds optimize for high-growth, higher-risk, and the unit economics reflect those different objectives and risk profiles. Specifically, IREN has expanded from a pure North American play into a global firm with a total of 5.8 GW owned power capacity as its USP with site acquisitions in Europe (Nostrum acquisition) and Australia. IREN's revenue is expected to improve with time and scale as utilization ramps, remaining contingent on execution of cloud deployment cycle and customer demand for enterprise scale compute. We see improvement in deal terms in the NVIDIA contract, (vs MSFT contract, assuming PUE for air cooled capacity to be 1.2) as revenue per IT-MW increased from \$9.5 Mn/IT-MW to \$14 Mn/IT-MW.
- As for **emerging AI infra** firms, WULF has a multi-state footprint in the US and now has contracts with neoclouds Core42 and Fluidstack (Google-backed) and has begun delivering data rooms. CIFR's sites are concentrated in Texas with nascent diversification with long term contracts with Fluidstack (Google) and AWS (2 separate contracts) - AWS returning as tenant for a deal is evidence of trust placed in CIFR's execution capability, with delivery slated to start in Q4CY26. Both CIFR and WULF demonstrate REIT-like characteristics with high visibility, contract-backed utilization and triple net (NNN) EBITDA margins (~80-95%) as assets stabilize, and future upside contingent on converting owned power sites into revenue-generating colocation contracts.

EXHIBIT 6: **Colocation Prov - Annualized Q OPEX per Active MW (\$M, 1Q23-1Q26)**



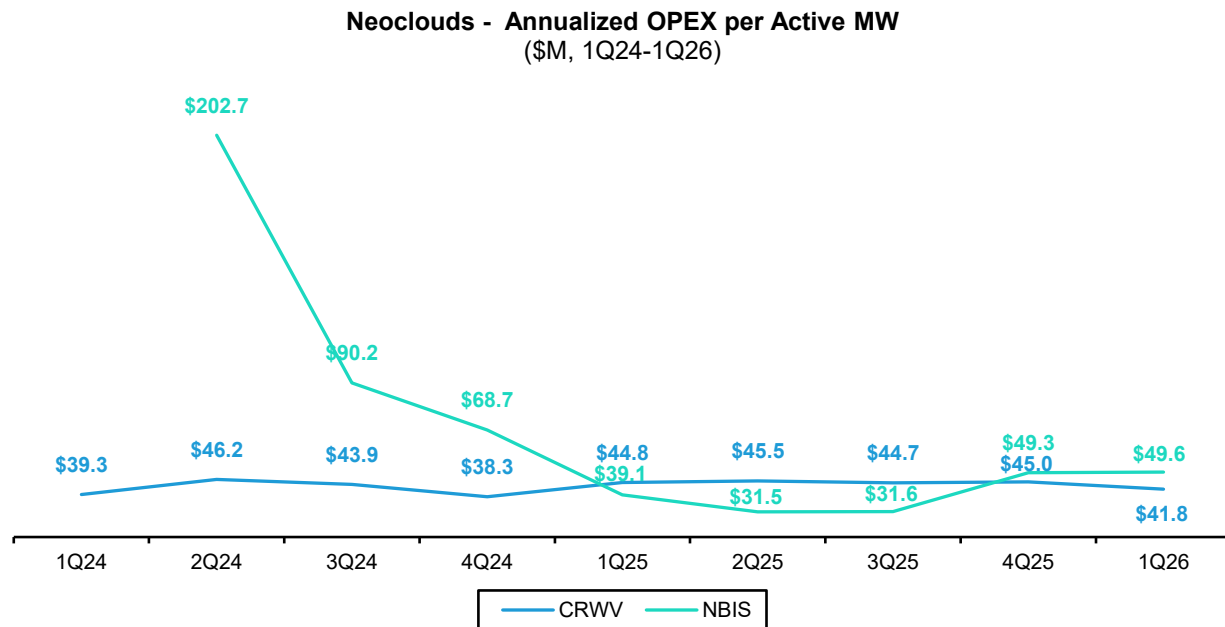
Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 7: **Colocation Prov - Operating Margin per Active MW (% , 1Q23-1Q26)**



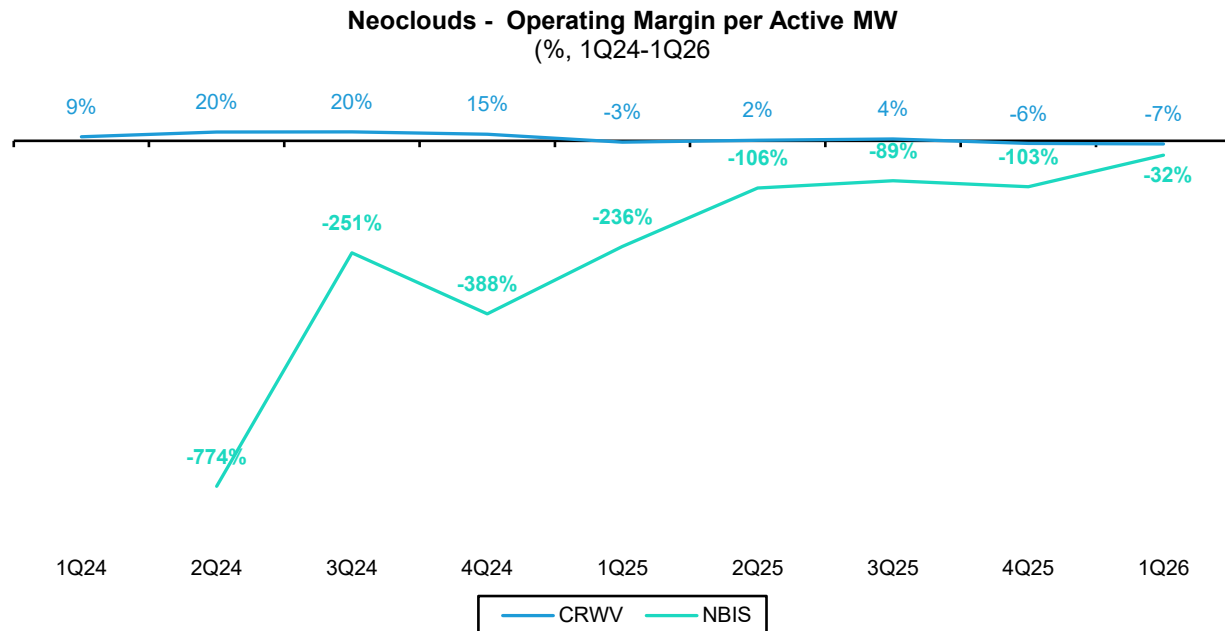
Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 8: **Neoclouds - Annualized Q OPEX per Active MW (\$M, 1Q24-1Q26)**



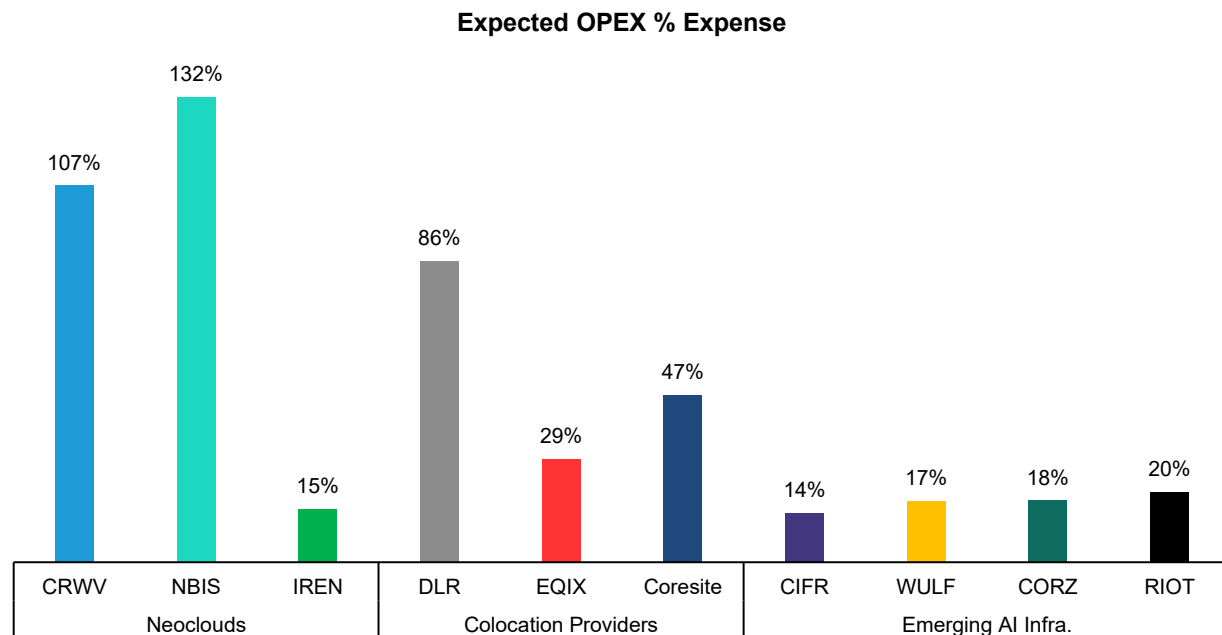
Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 9: **Neoclouds - Operating Margin per Active MW (% , 1Q24-1Q26)**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 10: **Expected OPEX % Expense**



IREN & Emerging AI Infra % are calculated based on disclosed contract's basis. For remaining figures 1Q26 figures are shown.

Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

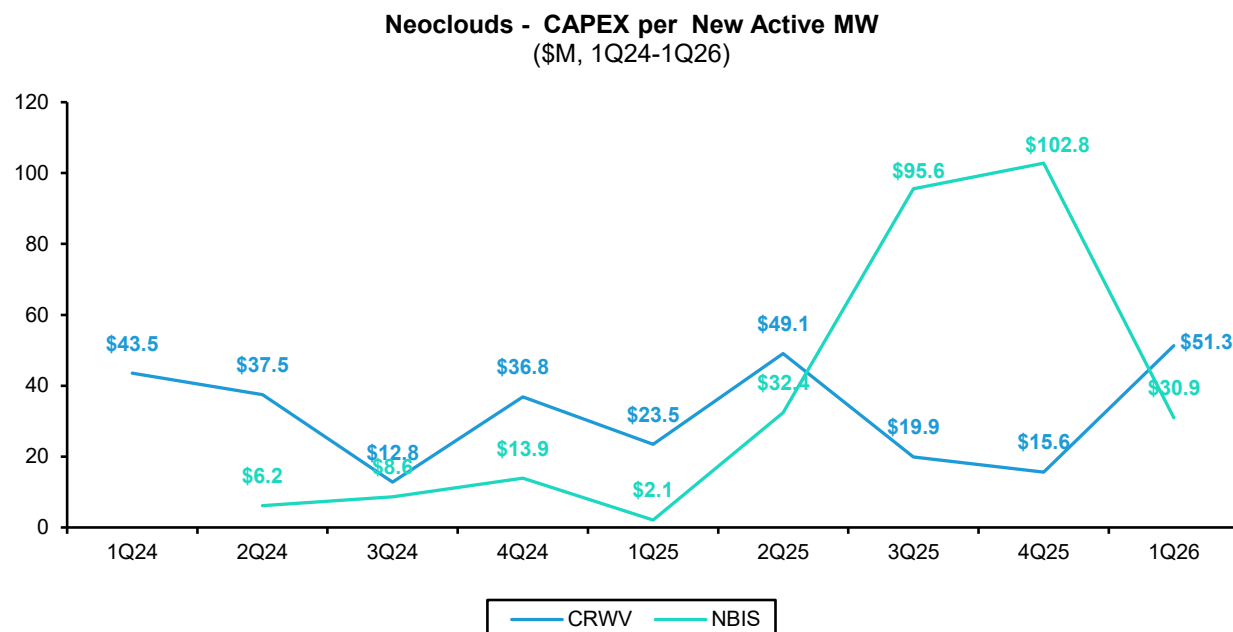
ASSET MIX AND CAPITAL INTENSITY

Data center REITs invest heavily in land, buildings, and core infrastructure (power distribution, cooling) and then lease capacity to tenants, recovering capital over long contracts; their revenue per MW reflects rent plus fees with little IT value-add.

Neoclouds often lease the data hall capacity from REITs and invest their balance sheet in GPUs, networking, and software, so

their revenue per MW of power includes returns on both leased physical capacity and owned IT assets. This lease-versus-owned split means that some OpEx per MW that would show up in a landlord's numbers is effectively embedded in a tenant's rent and does not directly appear in the neocloud's OpEx, while GPU depreciation and software operations make up OpEx per MW for the neocloud. Accordingly, Digital Realty's CapEx per MW remains the lowest at \$23.4M, while Equinix's \$58.1M sits closer to the neoclouds—with CoreWeave and Nebius at \$40.4M and \$54.1M respectively.

EXHIBIT 11: Neoclouds - CAPEX per New Active MW (\$M, 1Q24-1Q26)



Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

Across all firms (IREN, CIFR, WULF, CORZ), the major investment is similar to data center REITs in the powered shell for AI capacity, with IREN going a step further and incurring GPU capex under its vertically integrated cloud model. IREN's total capex (powered shell plus GPUs) comes to ~\$45M/MW for its liquid cooled Microsoft campus whereas CIFR and WULF operate with lower infrastructure capex intensity (~\$8-12M/MW) as tenants bring GPUs and IT stack, positioning them as capital-light "power landlords" with faster payback cycles and infrastructure-style returns.

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